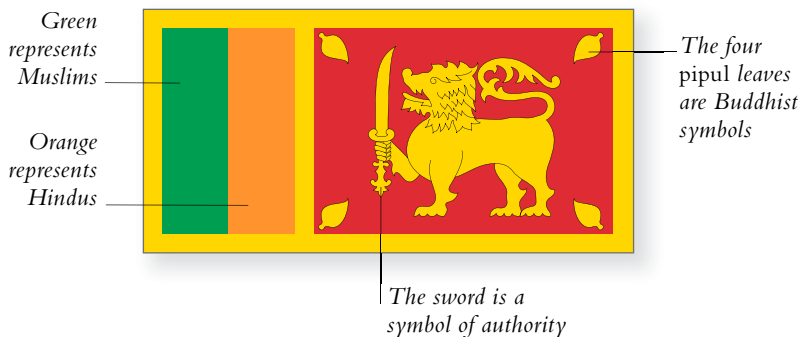


Sri Lanka

Ratio: 1:2 **Adopted:** December 17, 1978 **Usage:** National and Civil



Asia



The island of Ceylon was a British colony until independence in 1948. It became a republic under the name **Sri Lanka** in 1972.

The original flag of Sri Lanka featured just the lion and sword on a red field, recalling that the Sinhalese word for lion—"Sinhala"—is the basis of the island's name. The flag's yellow border symbolized the protection of the nation by Buddhism.

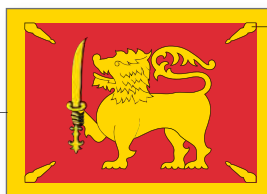
The flag was derived from the flag of the Sinhalese kingdom of Kandy. It proved unpopular with minority

groups, so vertical bands of green, for Muslims, and orange, for the Hindu Tamils, were added in 1951.

When the country's name changed from Ceylon to Sri Lanka in 1972, four leaves were added. They denote the tree under which Siddhartha sat when he received enlightenment and became the Buddha. This version of the flag was in official use from 1978.

FLAG OF KANDY

The "Lion Flag" was the national flag of Ceylon prior to 1815 when it became a British colony



The finials are derived from the spire on top of a Buddhist temple